

Writing Seminar: Claims, Grounds, and Warrants

One way to think about argument is using a method devised by Stephen Toulmin, a philosopher whose work has gained traction among rhetoricians and teachers of writing. In broadest strokes, “Toulmin’s method” contains three essential parts: **claim**, **grounds**, and **warrant**.

The **claim** is the purpose of the argument. You might also call it a “the point” (as in, “what’s the point of this paragraph?”). A claim is supported by **grounds**, or uncontested statements in context. For “grounds” you might think “evidence,” “facts,” or “data.” Finally, a **warrant** connects a claim and the grounds provided for that claim. Warrants are often framed as general rules, operating rationales, or common assumptions that allow you to think about claims and grounds together.

THE BASICS

Here’s an example I have modified, taken from the Purdue OWL (an excellent resource you should know about anyway):

CLAIM: There are dogs nearby.

GROUND: You hear barking and howling.

WARRANT: Dogs are animals that bark and howl.

Notice three things about this example:

First, the warrant gives a clear explanation for what the conclusion (DOGS) has to do with the evidence (BARKING). If you had never heard of a dog in your life, or you came from an alternative universe where dogs meowed instead of barking, you would be extremely confused by the claim. The **warrant** serves to clarify *why the grounds support the claim*.

Second, there is room to make different **claims**, even based on the same grounds. For example, wolves also bark and howl, as do coyotes. If you changed the **claim** to “There are coyotes nearby,” this would imply a change in the **warrant** as well, despite working from the same **grounds**. You might consider whether you live in a place where coyotes are more prevalent than dogs.

Third, this means that identifying the **warrant** allows for a way into qualifying or contradicting the **claim** without searching out new **grounds**. If it is the case that “dogs are animals that bark and howl,” it is also the case that “other animals bark and howl besides dogs.” This leaves room for there to be other animals nearby. You might qualify the **claim**: “There may be dogs nearby” – or “There may be dogs or coyotes nearby.”

Of course, one could quibble endlessly: what if it’s an audio recording of wolves? What if it’s your neighbors pretending to be dogs? What if you thought you heard barking, but the sound is actually meowing? What if you’ve gone insane? That’s philosophy for you! And, as it turns out, rhetoric, or having any opinions about anything whatsoever. The purpose of good argumentation is not to answer *every possible objection*, but to give a reasonable explanation for why your claim is well-supported by the evidence at hand.

THE BIRDS

Enough about dogs. Let's talk about birds! Here's a paragraph from an article in *The Verge* last year, about a sea eagle that escaped from the National Aviary in Pittsburgh and was on the lam for a week. This bird occupies a remarkable amount of my daily headspace:

Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss: he's large (although in Pittsburgh we probably wouldn't call him "giant" because "Giant Eagle" is a grocery store chain here), with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

Like many paragraphs that normal humans write for purposes other than academic example, there's a lot going on here! The paragraph is not broken into pure formula like the first example, above. It has a rhythm, a style. Still, we can identify a clear claim, followed by a series of grounds:

CLAIM: Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss[.]

GROUND: [H]e's large . . . with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

WARRANT: ???

Notice that *something is missing* here. We are looking at a classic example of an *unstated warrant* – i.e.:

WARRANT A: Birds that are large, with yellow beaks, white tail, and white tail feathers, that are bigger than a bald eagle, and that have six-foot wingspans are difficult to miss.

This is the sort of warrant that can be generalized further, in order to emphasize the specific claim:

WARRANT B: Large birds with distinctive features are difficult to miss.

You might have a hard time formulating an argument in terms of **warrant A**. It's extremely specific, for one thing, and its style hides its structure a bit. But **warrant B** allows you to see the kinds of assumptions that inform this particular form of journalistic argument. Is it big? Does it fly? You can't miss it!

You might want to ask how many large birds with distinctive features are flying around Pittsburgh, for example. They do have an aviary, after all. If large, white-and-yellow birds hang around all the time, maybe Kody could go incognito for a while. You might want to ask how good Kody is at disguising himself, or how high he tends to fly – such information would matter for the specific claim that he is not only noticeable but *noteworthy*. You might want to ask whether people, in general, actually pay attention to the birds they see: for whom, exactly, is it difficult to miss distinctive raptors.

Or, you might agree with the claim, based on the grounds and implied warrant! Sure, you say, big bird, distinctive colors, who wouldn't notice a thing like that? (Answer: everyone in Pittsburgh, apparently, for a week; oops.)

NB: I am happy to report that, ultimately, Kody was brought home without injury or health concerns.

PHILOSOPHY

Phaedrus and the God of Love

Here's the beginning of a paragraph from Phaedrus's introductory speech in Plato's *Symposium*, a text you now know and love:

All sides agree, then, that Love is one of the most ancient gods. As such, he gives to us the greatest goods. (178C)

Ok, your turn. Can you identify a **claim** here? What **grounds** are given?

Phaedrus has a bit of an unstated warrant here. (Phaedrus is plagued by multiplying unstated warrants!) What **warrant** might connect the claim to the grounds?

Phaedrus, for the Love of God

Here's the same paragraph, plus a sentence:

All sides agree, then, that Love is one of the most ancient gods. As such, he gives to us the greatest goods. I cannot say what greater good there is for a young boy than a gentle lover, or for a lover than a boy to love. (178C)

Supposing we understand the first sentence to provide the **grounds** (Love is one of the most ancient gods) for the **claim** (Love gives the greatest goods). Can we understand the third sentence to act as a **warrant** that explains what the one thing (being old) has to do with the other (giving goods)? Or do we understand it as a new claim – or as a new kind of evidence?

Here's another way to ask! What do lovers and their beloveds have to do with Love and the giving of great goods?

BEWARE!

In closing, I'll only note that the Toulmin model is most useful as a descriptive, diagnostic tool. You do not need – you should not try! – to compose every paragraph you write in any strict, robotic, formulaic mode. Write like yourself, an intelligent and capable thinking being in the world. Then, and only then, turn to tools such as this model in order to perceive what is working, and what may be missing, about what you have already written.

The Toulmin model is a tool, not a formula. It is useful! But it is not comprehensive. (Nothing, I am extremely happy to tell you, is!) Allow it to guide your argument, but never allow it to obscure your voice.

ASSIGNMENT:

Your assignment for this week has three parts:

1. **Before completing parts 2 and 3.** Read this informational sheet, or watch the corresponding video lecture, or both.
2. **No later than 48hrs before your seminar meeting.**
 - a. Locate your Canvas Group and its corresponding Google Document for this meeting.
 - b. Write an answer to the question about Phaedrus's third sentence, described above (and in the video).
 - c. Upload one paragraph from your first exercise that you think had a particularly effective or persuasive argument. (Please do not choose your opening or introductory paragraph.)
3. **Before your seminar meeting begins.**
 - a. Skim the materials that your peers have submitted.
 - b. Respond to the argumentative paragraph for which you have been designated lead respondent:
 - i. Identify the main **claim** of the paragraph, and highlight the sentence that captures that claim most clearly in **yellow**.
 - ii. Identify any **grounds** used to support that claim, and highlight sentence(s) that serve as grounds in **green**.
 - iii. Using Toulmin's method, write a warrant that directly connects **one** grounds provided to the claim.
 - iv. In your estimation, do the grounds provided effectively support what you understand to be the main claim of the paragraph? Why or why not? Write a brief note to your peer – you may be direct, but please also be kind.